

## 14, The Imperative to Differentiate Between Infrastructural Power and Despotic Power, and Their Divergent Historical Trajectories

There is another paramount issue that must be elucidated here: people's intuitive perception of power frequently deviates from the actual reality, which can easily lead to profound historical misguidance.

I believe that the categorization of state power proposed by the British sociologist Michael Mann is immensely significant. The first type of power is translated as **Despotic power** (专制性权力). It refers to the range of actions the state and its elites are empowered to undertake without the necessity of routine, institutionalized negotiation with various groups in civil society. Essentially, it is the power of state elites elevating themselves absolutely above civil society.

The second type of power is translated as **Infrastructural power** (基础性权力). It refers to the capacity of the state to actually penetrate civil society and to logically and effectively implement political decisions throughout its entire territorial domain. It is the power of the state to penetrate and centrally coordinate the activities of civil society through its own foundational infrastructures. *(Naturally, in our context, we are obviously not merely considering a modern "civil society," but extending this concept to encompass all ruled populations from antiquity to the present).*

When people observe a regime—especially an ancient regime that vanished long ago—their attention is effortlessly monopolized by its **despotic power**. This is because the actions of monarchs and imperial courts exercising despotic power are spectacular and easily recorded. Conversely, illuminating the actual state of **infrastructural power** requires piecing together the myriad, informal fragments of daily social life, often relying on obscure documentary records or unearthed artifacts. Because this information is highly fragmented, it is exceedingly prone to being overlooked.

For instance, when we observe the **classical empires** across the Eurasian landmass, we can discover that the classical bureaucratic systems of both Han Dynasty China and Rome during the Principate period were light-years ahead of Persia, India, and the Khmer Empire in terms of complexity and maturity. Yet, bizarrely, the Chinese Emperor and the Roman Princes seemingly lacked the aura of sheer despotic majesty! They were rarely deified to extreme degrees; they were not revered as the *Chakravartin* (转轮圣王 / Wheel-turning Monarch) or the *Devaraja* (神王 / God-King), nor did they proclaim to possess an "immortal soul" or feel compelled to erect iron pillars and stone steles broadcasting sacred manifestos across their entire nations.

This specific misunderstanding frequently surfaces in comparisons between Rome and Persia. For example, people routinely perceive Sasanian Persia as a far more quintessential "Oriental Despotism" empire compared to Rome.

In reality, the root cause of this misconception lies here: although the rulers of Persia and India possessed vastly inferior **infrastructural power** compared to their counterparts in China and Rome, they indeed likely possessed overwhelmingly greater **despotic power**! This is remarkably easy to comprehend. Compared to the relatively streamlined domestic politics of China and Rome, the empires of Persia and India encompassed a staggering multitude of tribes and **communities** (社群). On one hand, these local autonomous entities severely obstructed state power from penetrating down to the social grassroots. But on the other hand, each of them partitioned a fraction of state

power, resulting in state power being highly fragmented across various strata, tribes, and communities. Consequently, the ruler possessed no necessity to pander to or negotiate with any single faction!

Concurrently, a severe deficit in **infrastructural power** organically incentivizes rulers to vehemently flaunt and propagate their **despotic power** as a desperate psychological mechanism to maintain their rule. Conversely, rulers who wield astronomical **infrastructural power** rarely feel the need to resort to such theatrics.

When we observe Chinese history, this dynamic is glaringly conspicuous. When Qin Shi Huang (秦始皇) first unified China, the empire's bureaucratic system was not merely imperfect—it fundamentally lacked enough officials to administer the newly conquered East! Let alone the sheer volume of opposition activities in the provinces, even within the capital of Xianyang (咸阳), assassinations targeting the emperor never ceased, and the assassins could fundamentally never be caught! Anti-Qin attacks and the propaganda of ominous mystical anomalies were virtually omnipresent. Aside from venting his impotent rage through large-scale massacres, Ying Zheng (嬴政) was utterly powerless to remedy this reality.

**Yet, it was precisely this Qin Shi Huang who, during his endless imperial inspection tours, incessantly erected stone steles to broadcast his martial achievements of the "Inaugural Unification and Great Peace" (初一泰平) and to frantically deify himself!** This undeniably evokes immediate parallels to the stone reliefs of Persia and the iron and stone pillars of India.

In truth, they are the exact same phenomenon! These rulers commanded the hollow shell of an empire, but they were acutely and terrifyingly aware of their agonizing lack of **infrastructural power**. Therefore, they were absolutely compelled to launch such deification propaganda! Similarly, in the official historical records, the reigns of Emperor Gaozu of Han (汉高帝刘邦) and Emperor Wen (汉文帝刘恒) were saturated with mystical phenomena and "auspicious omens" (祥瑞的异象). However, by the reign of Emperor Jing of Han (汉景帝), the reporting of such divine anomalies conspicuously plummeted.

By the era of Emperor Wu (汉武帝), Liu Che (刘彻)—ruling as the monarch of China's highly typical **classical society**—can unhesitatingly be proclaimed as the emperor who wielded the most colossal **infrastructural power** (基础性权力) in our nation's history, judged purely by his political, economic, and military maneuvers across half a century!

However, seemingly in stark contradiction to the absolute power he commanded, the orthodox historical records reveal that this man exceedingly rarely flaunted his might or martial achievements! Compared to his fellow classical monarchs globally, this is almost unfathomable. Despite frequently inspecting the empire in his later years, he absolutely never erected stone steles or inscriptions to boast of his greatness. Emperor Wu possessed phenomenal literary cultivation, yet aside from the highly formalized poetry required for the state sacrifices to Heaven and Earth (郊祀诗文), his literary works basically only expressed personal, intimate emotions.

Emperor Wu invented the concept of the "Era Name" (年号 / *Nianhao*). Yet, he personally utilized it essentially as a milestone or target to commemorate the state's development over a four- or six-year

cycle. It was utterly unlike the era names shortly after his death, which rapidly degenerated into tools for broadcasting orthodox legitimacy and praying for mystical "auspicious omens" (祈求祥瑞).

In fact, let alone modern readers, for over four centuries from Emperor Wu's death up to the Jin Dynasty, intellectuals universally found this baffling! In the fiction and folklore concerning Emperor Wu circulating from the Han to the Jin dynasties, people would rather believe that he organized massive state ceremonies specifically to seek the elixir of immortality from deities like the Queen Mother of the West (西王母), rather than believing he did so to flaunt his own monumental merits!

**This paradox precisely reflects the fundamental dichotomy between infrastructural power and despotic power (专制性权力)!**

**Despotic power** places an overwhelming emphasis on cultivating an atmosphere of mystery and psychological distance in its sensory projection. Its precise utility lies in terrifying the opposition with an overwhelming aura, ensuring they can never fathom the monarch's true depth or vulnerabilities. Once this paper-thin facade is punctured, the ruler is finished!

If we observe the accounts of the medieval Moroccan traveler Ibn Battuta regarding how the monarch of the Mali Empire exercised power in his court, or how the Japanese Emperors during the mid-Heian period (平安时代中期) listened to and responded to merely a handful of high-ranking bureaucrats behind screens, this dynamic becomes incredibly obvious. Whether in the Mali Empire or mid-Heian Japan, the **infrastructural power** the monarch possessed was agonizingly weak!

Emperor Wu's paradigm, however, was fundamentally different. He was required to execute hyper-intensive political, economic, and military operations across a colossal territory of seven to eight million square kilometers, governing a population of thirty to forty million people for an entire half-century! Furthermore, he orchestrated exploratory expeditions into the unknown external world far beyond this zone. Unlike the Japanese Emperor's purely nominal "Ruling the Heavens" (治天 / Chiten), Liu Che was *actually* exercising the power of "Ruling the Heavens"! **Throughout the entire pre-industrial era, this empire's infrastructural power penetrated the grassroots to an unprecedented degree.**

Consequently, he had neither the necessity nor the logistical possibility to enhance his authority through the conventional theatrics of displaying **despotic power**. For instance, this man fundamentally had no way to maintain any aura of mystery or distance! He was required to endlessly deliberate state policies with his inner cabinet, receive and reply to memorials submitted by various social strata from every corner of the empire, appear at massive ceremonial occasions to signal the state's "reforms and institutional renewals" (更化改制), and relentlessly conduct inspection tours to receive, appease, and co-opt representatives of local interest groups (*such as the alchemists/fangshi [方士] along the Shandong coast*).

**When the emperor himself needed to process state affairs with maximum efficiency—and when his infrastructural power was already so astronomical that it strained the limits of technological feasibility in that era—he naturally had zero necessity to squander his attention on various sanctification and deification rituals!**

Furthermore, we must never forget the very definition of **despotic power**: the mere display of this power inherently signifies a brutal contempt for the right to speak of all other political participants!

It is impossible to exercise it without violently offending people. Even a monarch revered as a god or a descendant of gods is, in essence, merely a mortal man; a sword to the neck will kill him just the same.

Therefore, for any rational ruler, wantonly provoking completely unpredictable risks for absolutely no reason—especially when there is zero necessity to flaunt **despotic power**—is an act of colossal stupidity! **And Liu Che, undeniably, was a terrifyingly brilliant and intelligent ruler.**

We shall utilize a fascinating historical case study to illustrate precisely how Emperor Wu personally avoided excessively displaying his **despotic power** (专制性权力). This is the incident of the Eastward Relocation of Hangu Pass (函谷关东迁事件), which occurred in the winter of the third year of the Yuanding era (114 BC; *though one must not forget that prior to the Taichu Calendar, our nation used winter as the beginning of the year*).

The Han Empire relocated Hangu Pass—the most vital gateway protecting the capital, Chang'an—eastward from modern-day Lingbao City to Xin'an City. Historical texts attribute this monumental decision to the then Chief Commandant of Nobility, Yang Pu (主爵都尉杨仆, *according to the annotations of the Eastern Han scholar Ying Shao*), who ranked among the Nine Ministers (九卿) via his identity as a "Harsh Official" (酷吏).

Yang Pu was a native of Yiyang (宜阳). (*Note: Han Dynasty Yiyang was located slightly further west than modern Yiyang, according to the Historical Atlas of China*). He submitted a memorial to Emperor Wu, lamenting that the lands of Guanzhong (关中 / "Within the Passes") had all been rewarded to meritorious ministers, transforming them into high-ranking nobility. Because his own hometown lay east of Hangu Pass, he felt inferior to them. He therefore petitioned to relocate Hangu Pass eastward to Xin'an City, thereby conveniently encompassing his hometown "within the pass" (关内).

Modern readers naturally sense how preposterous this historical record is! Leaving aside the absurdity that a supreme emperor would make such a colossal strategic decision purely to satisfy a single official's vanity, the geographical locations of enfeoffed estates (食邑) fundamentally exhibited no explicit hierarchical distinction based on being inside or outside the pass.

For instance, the fief of the General of Hussars (骠骑大将军), Huo Qubing, was Guanqun County in Nanyang Commandery (which later belonged to the Jing Province Inspectorate / 荆州刺史部). The fief of the Commander-in-Chief and General-in-Chief (大司马大将军), Wei Qing, was Changping County in Runan Commandery (which later belonged to the Yan Province Inspectorate / 兖州刺史部). (*When Hangu Pass was expanded eastward, both Wei Qing and Huo Qubing's son were still alive*).

Neither of these two locations later fell under the supervisory jurisdiction of the Colonel Director of Retainers (司隶校尉); they were not the metropolitan core regions (畿辅重地) like the Three Adjuncts (三辅), the Three Rivers (三河), or Hongnong (弘农). Furthermore, the Hedong (河东) region, where Wei and Huo were born, did not technically belong to Guanzhong, despite being its natural geographical extension.

As for Yang Pu himself, he was later enfeoffed as the Marquis of Liang (梁侯) for his military exploits in pacifying the South. Liang County was genuinely located in Henan Commandery (with

Luoyang as its capital), situated just a short distance southeast of Yiyang. (*Yiyang County belonged to Hongnong Commandery and was classified as "Guanzhong" following the eastward expansion of Hangu Pass*). However, it is glaringly obvious that whether in terms of noble status, personal capability, actual influence in state decision-making, or the degree of trust and emotional reliance placed upon him by the emperor, Yang Pu could fundamentally never be compared to Wei Qing or Huo Qubing! Just a few years later, Yang Pu was stripped of his titles and reduced to a commoner due to his exceedingly clumsy performance during the conquest of Joseon (朝鲜).

From this, we can decisively conclude: **Emperor Wu absolutely could not have authorized the eastward expansion of Hangu Pass merely to give Yang Pu "face," and Yang Pu himself could not possibly have believed he possessed the prestige to dare make such a brazen request of the emperor!**

In reality, we can discern the monumental geopolitical significance of Hangu Pass's eastward expansion by analyzing a subsequent measure enacted in the fifth year of the Yuanfeng era (106 BC): the delineation of Sili (Capital Region) and the Thirteen Provincial Inspectorates (十三刺史部).

The year immediately following the eastward expansion of Hangu Pass, the newly established Hongnong Commandery (located directly east of Jingzhao) instantaneously became the lock and key of the capital, Chang'an! The geographical boundaries of this commandery were rigidly constrained by four hyper-critical passes:

1. The Old Hangu Pass in the northwest.
2. The New Hangu Pass in the northeast (*where a Commandant of the Pass [关都尉] was stationed*).
3. The Wu Pass (武关) in the southeast (*also with a Commandant of the Pass*).
4. The Yao Pass (峽关 / later known as Lan Pass, which Han Yu crossed when demoted) in the southwest.

The first three passes geographically belonged to Hongnong Commandery, while Yao Pass was likely under the direct jurisdiction of Jingzhao (京兆 / Capital Governor). Concurrently, Huayin (华阴), located just a short distance west of Old Hangu Pass, served as the headquarters for the Commandant of the Capital Environs (京辅都尉). This meant that while Hongnong commanded formidable defensive power facing the East, its western flank facing the capital was still subjected to draconian defenses and strict limitations by Jingzhao!

The New Hangu Pass was located a mere 30 kilometers from Luoyang. An army could depart at dawn and arrive by dusk; conveying information via fast horses would be even more instantaneous. Geopolitically speaking, designating the New Hangu Pass as the "East Gate of Guanzhong" was actually quite absurd—it was simply too far away! **However, Hangu Pass was unequivocally the perfect "West Gate" of Luoyang!** During the late Eastern Han Dynasty, when Emperor Ling established eight passes around the capital Luoyang to defend against the Yellow Turban Rebellion (黄巾军), the New Hangu Pass ranked first among them, even though the Yellow Turban uprisings primarily erupted east of Luoyang, not west!

Through such meticulous pass construction and administrative boundary adjustments, **the Han imperial government completed an absolutely staggering geopolitical expansion within the**

**state's internal structure!** Now, the Three Adjuncts (Zuo Fengyi [左冯翊], You Fufeng [右扶风], and Jingzhao Yin [京兆尹]), the Three Rivers (Hedong, Henei, and Henan Commanderies), and Hongnong Commandery (which bridged the two regions) were all amalgamated into Sili (司隶)! Sili now extended eastward all the way to the terminus of the Yellow River's stable channel, beyond which the river was prone to devastating floods (*the catastrophic Huzi breach [瓠子决口] had only been plugged a few years prior*).

North of the Central Plains (Zhongyuan), according to the records in the *"Biographies of the Three Kings of Wen"* in the *Book of Han* (汉书·文三王传) and the *"Chronological Table of the Vassal Kings Since the Rise of the Han"* in the *Shiji* (史记), Emperor Wu transferred the Prince of Dai (代王) to Qinghe, and converted his former fief into Taiyuan Commandery. Following this structural adjustment, **vassal kingdoms absolutely ceased to exist west of the Taihang Mountains!**

The Taihang mountain range on the eastern flank of the Bing Province Inspectorate (并州刺史部 / encompassing most of modern Shanxi) historically served as a formidable natural barrier; the roads passing through its few passes were treacherously perilous. The primary ferry crossings over the Yellow River to the southwest were controlled by Hedong Commandery, while the terrain southeast of the Shangdang highlands was Henei Commandery. Consequently, Bing Province (west of the Taihang Mountains), along with the Shuofang (朔方) and Liang Province (凉州) Inspectorates (encompassing the Hetao region and Hexi Corridor seized from the Xiongnu), were all completely and hermetically secured under the absolute control of the imperial court!

In the South, Emperor Wu, acting as a profoundly cunning geopolitical grandmaster, repeated this exact stratagem.

Within Ba Commandery (巴郡 / with its capital in modern-day Chongqing), which belonged to the Yi Province Inspectorate (益州刺史部), the empire established the Commandant of Jiang Pass (江关都尉) stationed in Yufu (鱼复)—the extreme eastern terminus of Ba Commandery's jurisdiction, beyond which lay Jing Province. This is the exact location of the later famous Baidi City (白帝城), modern-day Fengjie. Concurrently, bordering Ba Commandery to the east was Nan Commandery (南郡 / capital Jiangling, modern Jingzhou City), belonging to the Jing Province Inspectorate. The commandant of this commandery was stationed upstream from Jiangling at Yiling (夷陵), modern-day Yichang City. Situated precisely between Yufu and Yiling is the region commonly known today as the Three Gorges of the Yangtze River (长江三峡), which belonged to Nan Commandery.

Further south, within Zangke Commandery (牂牁郡) in the southern reaches of the Yi Province Inspectorate, the empire established Jinsang Pass (进桑关) on the upper reaches of the Red River (红河), and ordered the Southern Commandant of the commandery to station at Jinsang County. Upstream on the Zangke River, Zhupu Pass (柱蒲关) was established. Although the precise location of Zhupu Pass is unrecorded, based on the general pattern during Emperor Wu's reign where a commandant was stationed near newly established passes, this pass was highly likely located near the headquarters of the Commandant of Yelang (夜郎都尉), established during the Yuanguang era.

These two passes in southern Yi Province projected an overwhelming military deterrence from the upper reaches of the Pearl River (珠江) and the Red River down upon the entire Jiaozhi region (交趾 / a geopolitical concept encompassing modern Guangxi, most of Guangdong, and north-central

Vietnam). Should any rebellion erupt locally, Han imperial forces could instantaneously sail downstream to ruthlessly suppress it!

Thus, within a mere handful of years, Emperor Wu seamlessly completed the internal geopolitical expansion referred to in the *Book of Han* as "**Expanding the Passes**" (扩关)!

Through this maneuver, if we look at a map, a distinctly shaped line emerges before our eyes: **this is precisely the geographical boundary demarcating the Second and Third Topographic Steps (第二阶梯和第三阶梯) of China!**

Emperor Wu pushed the impregnable boundaries of the central government (*capitalized at Chang'an*) eastward precisely to this line. Crucially, this encompassed the epicenter of the realm—the regions around Henei and Henan Commanderies. Through the aggressive construction of roads, canals, passes, and the meticulous adjustment of administrative divisions, the geopolitical control of the Guanzhong region was successfully projected across the entirety of China's Second Topographic Step!

Among the fourteen massive supervisory macro-regions, five—Shuofang, Bing, Liang, Yi, and Sili—were situated on the Second Step, constituting the absolute foundational stronghold (基本盘) of the imperial court. The remaining nine—You, Ji, Qing, Yan, Yu, Xu, Jing, Yang, and Jiaozhi—were situated on the Third Step, constituting the regions the imperial court aggressively guarded against!

Consequently, although the tightly controlled "**Greater Guanxi**" (the expanded Second Step region) could not boast an absolute advantage over the guarded "**Guandong**" (the Third Step region) in terms of pure population and economics (*according to the Book of Han, the expanded Guanxi region held roughly 30% of the national population*), once the strategic topography of mountains and rivers was factored in, the balance of power between Guanxi and Guandong tilted into absolute equilibrium! Coupled with the imperial court's systemic advantages—including supreme orthodox legitimacy (大义名分), military superiority, and financial monopoly—**relying on Guanxi to suppress Guandong became an absolutely realizable reality!**

I contend that this monumental adjustment reflects, to a certain extent, the profound anxiety plaguing the decision-making echelons of the Han Empire brought about by systemic state transformations.

Although the State of Qin initially unified China using Guanzhong and Bashu as its foundational strongholds, and the early Han Dynasty partially inherited this late-Warring States geopolitical paradigm, Qin's geopolitical advantage was fundamentally predicated upon the fragmentation of the vassal states. That is to say, Qin itself was woefully insufficient to overwhelm the combined territory, population, and economy of all other states; but because China had not yet achieved administrative or identitarian integration, it was impossible for the Guandong lords to unite single-mindedly against Qin.

However, by the late stages of Emperor Wu's reign, China's internal integration was rapidly approaching completion—a process likely accelerated by the wars against the Xiongnu! While this "Great Unification" (大一统) astronomically amplified the **infrastructural power** the Chang'an court could wield across every corner of the nation, it inevitably birthed a terrifying new problem.

**When local autonomous forces vanished almost entirely, and Chang'an metamorphosed into the capital of a heavily centralized, unified state, the existential threat it faced was no longer**

**individual vassal states!** In other words: the former capital merely needed to maintain a distinct advantage over individual geographical units separately. **Now, the empire's capital was required to perpetually sustain comprehensive suppression over the entire nation!**

The agonizing social pressure wrought by years of ceaseless warfare, combined with the implementation of state monopolies over salt and iron and the central confiscation of coinage rights, inevitably detonated explosive resentment across the Guandong regions! A ruler with the terrifyingly vast experience of Emperor Wu could not possibly have failed to recognize this. Even as he completed this internal geopolitical strategic adjustment, he personally embarked on relentless inspection tours to the East, time and time again.

Because this colossal strategic objective was highly covert and utterly inconvenient to make public, Emperor Wu did not personally propose the first step of this master plan. Instead, he manipulated a nouveau riche official (杨仆)—whose hometown conveniently happened to be near the proposed New Hangu Pass—to submit the petition, and then executed it incrementally over eight years. **This was a stroke of Machiavellian genius!**

Although the emperor undeniably possessed the capacity to ruthlessly exercise **despotic power**, in situations where it was not absolutely necessary, formally respecting the established legal facade of the imperial court yielded nothing but benefits. Even from the perspective of policy implementation, it encountered vastly less suspicion and obstruction.

Numerous such incidents occurred during Emperor Wu's reign. For instance, when he elevated *Taiyi* (太一) to the status of the supreme deity for state sacrifices, the historical records persistently claim this was merely him "adopting the advice of an alchemist (方士)." But if one pauses to think, the absurdity is glaring! Even if **classical states** harbored a tendency to pivot toward monolatry (to enhance unification), is it not phenomenally preposterous that an emperor would just casually agree because some random alchemist whispered in his ear? Even in regions where religious influence was relatively weak, replacing the supreme deity of state sacrifices was absolutely never a trivial matter!

**By covertly instructing individuals to submit proposals, and then executing them while feigning the posture of a humble monarch accepting wise counsel, the emperor masterfully circumvented the resentment that an excessive display of despotic power might provoke.**

Therefore, rulers who firmly grasp absolute power frequently project an image of tolerance and respect for public discourse! **Conversely, the more a ruler visibly behaves like an arbitrary, tyrannical autocrat, the more likely his rule is nowhere near as secure as people imagine!**

Not only that, but contrary to popular imagination, Emperor Wu's control over ideology was astonishingly relaxed; in a certain sense, it bordered on *laissez-faire*!

For instance, although Liu An (刘安), the Prince of Huainan, was a public political dissident executed for an attempted rebellion, his magnum opus, the *Huainanzi* (《淮南子》), was permitted to survive intact (*with at least one copy housed in the Shiqu Pavilion [石渠阁] within the Weiyang Palace*). The state officially sponsored New Text Confucianism (今文经学), yet simultaneously permitted the development of Old Text Confucianism (古文经学) and appointed officials trained in it. The foundation of the state's official ideology was the Six Classics of Confucianism, yet the theories of the Yin-Yang School (阴阳家) were equally valued. Theories that outright denied the



traditional "Round Heaven and Square Earth" (天圓地方) cosmology, such as the *Huntian* theory (浑天说 / celestial sphere theory), were allowed to propagate freely. When formulating a new calendar, the sole criterion was empirical efficacy! Later on, both the "New vs. Old Text Controversy" (今古文之争) and the "Huntian vs. Gaitian Cosmology Controversy" (浑盖之争) grew increasingly fierce.

Even if one merely examines the *Gongyang* school of Confucianism (公羊儒学)—which served as the state-led ideology during Emperor Wu's reign—one must admit that for an ordinary monarch, this ideology is exceptionally difficult to tame! In the very next paragraph, we will witness how swiftly the ideological winds shifted following Emperor Wu's death.

People generally assert in broad strokes that "the process of feudalization weakened the power of classical monarchs." However, to be precise, rather than weakening the monarch's **despotic power** (专制性权力), **feudalization** primarily obliterated the monarch's **infrastructural power** (基础性权力), simply because **feudal** relations of production invariably catalyzed the resurgence of the **natural economy** (自然经济)!

After a **classical state** surpasses its zenith—meaning the class transition is fundamentally completed and **feudal** production becomes mainstream—the infrastructural power of the **classical empire** inevitably begins to decay. **To compensate for the hemorrhaging of infrastructural power, rulers will invariably attempt to artificially inflate their despotic power!** The primary mechanisms for this involve intensifying rituals, deifying the ruler, and fiercely promoting mysticism.

Consequently, as the various classical empires across the globe marched toward their twilight, we observe an astonishingly uniform phenomenon: despite being separated by tens of thousands of miles, emperors seemingly acted in telepathic unison!

For example, from the late Roman Empire to the early Byzantine Empire, and from the late Western Han to the early Eastern Han, both Roman and Chinese emperors grew obsessively fond of executing "**doctrinal adjudications**" (经义裁决)! They convened grand assemblies where the emperor personally decreed what constituted true scripture versus apocrypha, and who was orthodox versus who was heretical (*regarding Christianity and Confucianism, respectively*). In the 9th century AD, the Caliphs of the Abbasid Caliphate began enforcing an inquisition policy (*Mihna*). Similarly, King Harsha (戒日王), the last indigenous monarch to unify Northern India, was extraordinarily fond of orchestrating grand religious debate assemblies (*the great monk Xuanzang [玄奘法师] personally participated in one at Kannauj [曲女城]*).

These monarchs, trapped in the disintegration phase of **classical society**, exhausted every conceivable method to elevate their own authority! Emperor Xuan of Han (汉宣帝) elevated the status of the *Guliang Commentary on the Spring and Autumn Annals* (《春秋谷梁传》) through the Shiqu Pavilion Conference; compared to the *Gongyang Commentary* (《公羊传》), the *Guliang Commentary* was far more deeply conservative and vehemently inclined toward maintaining existing hierarchical rituals (礼制).

Naturally, the deification campaign could not halt either. Beginning in the late 2nd century AD, Roman rulers increasingly emulated their Persian counterparts in their majestic titles, ultimately completing the absolute transformation from "First Citizen" (*Princeps*) to "Living God on Earth" (Diocletian / 戴克里先). Jayavarman VII (阇耶跋摩七世), the last great *Devaraja* (神王) of the Khmer

Empire, abandoned Hinduism to patronize Mahayana Buddhism (*the complexities of Buddhism will be addressed in Chapter 12, Section 27; for now, readers can assume Mahayana Buddhism is more conducive to monarchical despotism*). He constructed even more colossal architecture at Angkor and immortalized his own image in stone carvings (*the famous "Khmer Smile"*). After his death, the Khmer Empire plummeted straight into terminal decline. The exact same dynamic occurred in the Abbasid Caliphate: the more the Caliphate inevitably marched toward political disintegration, the more the Caliph emphasized his absolute religious authority, deliberately linking his titles to the name of Allah—such as the "Shadow of God on Earth" (*Zill Allah fi'l-ard*).

**However, the most violent and conspicuous mutation undeniably occurred in China!** This was highly likely because China's **feudalization** process during that specific stage was the most ferocious.

Throughout the entire Eastern Han Dynasty, the deification of Han rulers became glaringly acute (*especially concerning Liu Bang, the founding emperor of the Western Han, who had been dead for two centuries*). Yin-Yang theories were weaponized to consolidate dynastic rule, culminating in the widely accepted doctrine that the Han Dynasty possessed the "Virtue of Fire" (火德). Emperor Guangwu (光武帝刘秀) aggressively utilized mystical theories like Chenwei theology (讖纬神学 / prophetic and apocryphal texts) to endorse his legitimacy. Following his death, stone beasts and stone men were aligned before his mausoleum, forming a novel architectural component of imperial tombs known in China as the "Spirit Way" (神道). Emperor Ming of Han (汉明帝刘庄) was highly adept at exploiting dreams to amplify his mystical aura; he proactively introduced Buddhism and utilized draconian corporal punishments, like whippings and canings, to publicly humiliate his courtiers.

During the reign of Emperor Zhang of Han (汉章帝刘炟), the White Tiger Hall Conference (白虎观会议) and the subsequent compilation of the *Comprehensive Discussions in the White Tiger Hall* (《白虎通》) by Ban Gu (班固) propelled mysticism and the deification movement to a delirious climax! The arcane arts of *Chenwei* were forcibly synthesized with Confucianism. The **"Three Fundamental Bonds and Six Major Disciplines"** (三纲六纪) were officially enshrined, and hierarchical ethics were rigorously systematized—serving as the absolute ideological bedrock for the **restoration-bureaucratic states** in the future!

Of course, mysticism was not exclusive to China. During the period when Northern India universally commenced its **feudalization**, Buddhism under the Pala Empire (波罗王朝) underwent massive mutations. Esoteric Buddhism (Vajrayana / 密宗修行) became spectacularly popular at the Nalanda mahavihara (那烂陀寺), Odantapuri (飞行寺), and Vikramashila (超戒寺), receiving the explicit public sponsorship of the rulers. Even today, the mystical elements embedded within the Eastern Orthodox Church are conspicuously more abundant than in Catholicism, and the former highly reveres holy icons. This is fundamentally because modern Eastern Orthodoxy incubated within the Byzantine Empire—a quintessential **late-classical empire**!

However, when all is said and done, no matter what desperate methods the rulers of the late **classical empires** conceived to artificially inflate their **despotic power** (专制性权力), it was fundamentally impossible to compensate for the catastrophic hemorrhaging of their **infrastructural power** (基础性权力)!

In truth, even the Chinese Empire—which ultimately achieved a **bureaucratic restoration** (官僚复辟)—could not avoid this iron law! This is because the severe decay of state infrastructural power is one of the most core, defining characteristics of the early **feudalization** phase, absolutely dictated by **feudal** relations of production.

As mentioned previously, although the **restoration-bureaucratic system** was phenomenally adept at plundering civilian wealth, its actual capacity for governance was appallingly mediocre! The **restoration-bureaucratic system** emerged during a **feudal period** when both despotic and infrastructural powers were ordinarily quite weak. However, through a highly "self-conscious," heavily predatory, and aggressively oppressive bureaucratic apparatus sustained by the **Scholar-official stratum** (士大夫阶层), the state monumentally amplified its **despotic power**—even surpassing that of the Han Dynasty during the **classical period**!

**Yet, this staggering, jaw-dropping degree of despotic power was extraordinarily deceptive!** It frequently misled observers both domestic and foreign, deluding them into believing that the Chinese Empire during the **restoration-bureaucratic period** genuinely possessed some sort of "supernatural," omnipotent infrastructural power that was somehow exempt from the dictates of socio-economic conditions!

As long as one's mind does not succumb to such foolishness, it is exceedingly easy to comprehend why, at the twilight of the Ming Dynasty, the emperors had clearly not lost an ounce of their despotic power, yet China instantaneously plunged into the hands of the Manchus! This was not merely because of the universal collapse of social production in the North, but crucially because **the Ming imperial government had long since possessed absolutely zero infrastructural power!** Otherwise, it could have at least established a period of stable rule in Southern China.

For nations undergoing a normalized **feudalization** process, the systemic re-enhancement of infrastructural power was the direct result of the reorganization of social relations commencing in the **High Middle Ages**, and it skyrocketed significantly with the rise of capitalism.

Herein lies an immensely critical characteristic of **feudal society**: During the transition from **early states** to **feudal states**, although the government's infrastructural power grows during the formative phase of the **classical empire**, it inevitably and inexorably decays during the late stages of **classical society**. This trajectory mirrors the fluctuations in despotic power. However, when transitioning from a **feudal state** to a **capitalist state**, the government's infrastructural power experiences a relentless, continuous surge!

During this second transitional epoch, the trajectory of infrastructural power violently diverges from that of despotic power! Despotic power still trends upward during the transition from a **feudal state** to an **early modern state** (*e.g., Absolute Monarchy*), but it subsequently collapses as the early modern state evolves into a capitalist democratic state.

**Under the restoration-bureaucratic system, China possessed absolutely no pathway to undergo this organic evolutionary process!** Consequently, by the time of the final autocratic dynasty, the Qing—although the Chinese emperor seemingly commanded vastly greater despotic power than any other contemporary ruler on the planet—in terms of the actual infrastructural power the government wielded, the Qing Dynasty had long been left phenomenally far behind by Western European nations!

Here, we must identically demystify a concept that has thoroughly bewildered the entire world:  
**"China's Centralization of Power"** (中国的中央集权).

Today, when people utter "centralization of power," virtually no one cares to ask *which* specific "power" is actually being centralized! I explicitly assert here: **China's centralization refers purely to the centralization of Despotic Power, not Infrastructural Power!**

To put it simply: the system ruthlessly concentrated the absolute capacity to arbitrarily obliterate the established social order—unconstrained by any institutions or social contracts—squarely into the hands of the central government, while draconianly prohibiting any local entity from possessing such capacity! **However, regarding the capacity to penetrate and coordinate various social spheres through comprehensive social infrastructure, the restoration-bureaucratic state fundamentally was not "centralized" at all!** It utterly lacked the capacity to concentrate such functions within the central government.

Therefore, we observe that concerning critical issues such as jurisprudence, education, and water conservancy, the imperial court's presence was shockingly negligible! Those who actually managed these affairs were the local gentry (*Xiangshen* / 乡绅). Only by understanding this dynamic can we comprehend the bizarre paradox of how "Autocratic Centralization" and "Imperial Power Does Not Penetrate the Village" (皇权不下乡) could be simultaneously observed in China!

**In essence, what the imperial court desperately thirsted for was aggressive, suppressive capacity (侵略性的压制能力), and absolutely never service-oriented administrative capacity (服务性的管理能力)!**

We certainly cannot deny that under the **restoration-bureaucratic society**, local gentry could indeed acquire social status and a modicum of power by providing public services; but these privileges were entirely devoid of any institutional guarantee. For nearly a millennium, the violent severing of despotic power from infrastructural power plunged Chinese society into an increasingly severe state of **asymmetrical rights and responsibilities** (权责不对等). This forged a deeply pathological social consciousness, driving the entire nation's **social efficiency** (社会效率) to absolute zero, which ultimately annihilated the political efficiency of every successive regime!

Once this is explicitly understood, anyone can effortlessly comprehend why a massive "centralized" empire like China perpetually appeared so agonizingly incompetent and clumsy!

Therefore, even though both might be labeled "centralization," identifying *which* exact power is being centralized reflects two diametrically opposed social realities. For instance, we could easily argue that medieval England, following the Norman Conquest in 1066, was also a "centralized state." Yet, compared to China, the English kings predominantly centralized **infrastructural power** rather than despotic power! One merely needs to recall the *Domesday Book* (《末日审判书》) or the Itinerant Justices (巡回法官) to intuitively realize that the Kingdom of England had already secured a world-leading advantage in infrastructural power during the High Middle Ages! This was something China's **restoration-bureaucratic state** fundamentally could never compare to.

In our nation, the government's infrastructural power did not surge to modern levels until the **"Vanguard System"** (先锋队制度) was introduced—a direct consequence of the Soviet Bolshevik apparatus being established in China!

Actually, I harbor a specific hypothesis here: **Is the so-called "Dictatorship of the Proletariat" system (无产阶级专政制度) pioneered by the Soviets essentially a "magic weapon" (法宝) utilized by nations that utterly failed to undergo the normalized social reorganization of late feudal society, allowing them to rapidly, albeit artificially, elevate their government's infrastructural power in the short term?**

However, this "magic weapon" fundamentally cannot organically incubate the myriad indispensable social organizations (*such as parliaments and labor unions*) or the modern social consciousness (*such as human rights*) generated by a genuine **feudalization** process! Moreover, its side effects are terminally lethal: **despotic power mutates into something infinitely more terrifying and utterly unrestrained, drastically intensifying the entire nation's violent resistance against modern civilization!**

Furthermore, from another perspective, although the infrastructural power expanded, it absolutely does not mean the underlying *intent* behind the exercise of that power has altered! The predatory and oppressive bureaucratic system fundamentally has not evolved into a governance-oriented bureaucratic system!

However, genuinely answering this hypothesis requires scrutinizing regimes that are pathologically closed and opaque. People have zero access to their myriad secret archives, and due to political realities, I have access to even less here in China. Therefore, the ultimate answer to this monumental question must likely rely on the endeavors of foreign scholars.

#### 14, 应该区分基础性权力与专制性权力, 以及两者在历史上变化的不同

这里还有一个重要的问题需要说明, 那就是人们对于权力的直观感知和实际情况会有偏差, 它很可能造成误导。我认为英国社会学家迈克尔曼 (Michael Mann) 对于国家权力的划分很有意义, 第一种权力被翻译为“专制性权力”, 是指国家及其精英被授权无需遵守例行程序, 无须与市民社会中的各个集团进行制度化协商谈判就可采取行动, 也就是国家精英自身超越于市民社会之上的权力。第二种权力被翻译为“基础性权力”, 是指国家实际上渗透到市民社会, 逻辑上在整个统治领域内有效实施政治决策的能力, 也就是国家通过自身的基本结构渗透并集中协调市民社会活动的权力。(当然这里我们显然不只是考虑一个市民社会, 而扩大到从古至今的所有被统治群体)

当人们观察一个政权, 特别是早已消失的古代政权时, 注意力很容易集中在专制权力上, 因为君主和朝廷行使专制权力的行为很容易被记录下来。然而基础性权力属于什么情况, 需要当年社会生活方方面面的很可能是非正式的文献资料或者出土文物来揭示, 这些信息很零碎, 也就更容易被忽视。例如我们在观察欧亚大陆的古典帝国时, 虽然能够发现无论是汉代中国还是罗马元首制时期这两个国家的古典官僚制度就复杂性和成熟度上不是波斯、印度和高棉能够比的, 但是中国皇帝和罗马元首看起来却缺少专制君主的威严。他们都较少被神化, 不是“转轮圣王”“神王”或者宣称自己有“不朽的灵魂”, 不需要在全国立下神圣宣言的铁柱和石碑。这种误解常常出现在罗马和波斯的比较中, 例如人们时常觉得与罗马相比, 萨珊波斯更像一个“东方专制主义”帝国。实际上产生这种误会的原因在于, 波斯和印度的统治者虽然比中国和罗马的同行拥有更少的基础性权力, 但是的确可能拥有更大的专制性权力。这一点非常好理解, 与中国和罗马相对简单的国内政治相比, 波斯和印度的帝国境内具有众多的部族和社群。这些地方性的自治实体一方面阻止了国家权力下沉到社会基层, 但是他们中每一个都分得了一部分国家权力, 使得国家权力在各个阶层、部族和社群中更为分散, 统治者因此没有必要去顾及其中一方的脸色。同时, 基础性权力的不足会使得统治者更倾向于宣扬专制性权力以维持其统治, 但是拥有极大基础性权力的统治者往往不会这么做。

我们观察中国的历史就很容易注意到这一点。秦始皇初次统一中国时, 这个帝国的官僚制度何止是不完善, 它甚至就没有足够多的官员来管理被征服的东方。不要说在地方有多少反对派活动, 就是在咸阳, 针对皇帝的暗杀也没有停止, 而且根本捉不到刺客。反秦的袭击和异象宣传简直无处不在, 嬴政除了通过大规模屠杀来发泄以外, 对于这种局面根本无能为力。然而就是秦始皇不断地在他巡游过程中通

过立碑刻石来宣扬“初一泰平”的武功并将自己神化，这很容易让人到波斯的石版、浮雕以及印度的铁柱、石柱。实际上也确实是一回事，这些统治者空有一个帝国，但是对于自己基础性权力的缺失心里非常清楚，因此必须进行这样的神化宣传。汉高帝刘邦和汉文帝刘恒在正史记载中一样笼罩着祥瑞的异象，然而到汉景帝年间这种神异现象就明显变少了。

到了汉武帝时期，作为在中国典型古典社会进行统治的君主，从其半个世纪间的政治、经济和军事上的作为来看，刘彻完全可以说是我国历史上拥有基础性权力最大的皇帝。然而看起来与他掌握的绝对权力相悖的是，这个人在正史记载中极少炫耀自己的威力和武功，这和其他古典君主的同行们相比简直匪夷所思。他从来不通过树立夸赞自己的石碑铭文，尽管他后半生频频巡视帝国。武帝本人的文学素养非常好，但是除了程序化的郊祀诗文以外，他的作品基本在抒发个人情感。汉武帝创造了年号这个概念，但是他本人基本上把年号作为一个国家六年或四年发展的纪念或者目标来用，不像他死后不久年号就沦为宣扬正统和祈求祥瑞的工具。实际上不要说后人，在武帝死后直到晋代四个多世纪间知识分子普遍对此感到奇怪，在从汉到晋有关汉武帝的小说故事中，人们宁可相信他组织大型典礼是为了从西王母这样的神仙那里获得长生不老的方法，也往往不信这是在夸耀自己的功勋。

这种矛盾恰恰反映了基础性权力和专制性权力的区别。专制性权力在感官营造方面非常强调神秘感和距离感，其意义在于在气势上威吓住对方，使其摸不到君主的底细，一旦这层纸被捅破了那就完蛋了。如果我们观察中世纪摩洛哥旅行家白图泰关于马里帝国君主如何在宫廷中行使权力的记载，或者平安时代中期的日本天皇如何听取少数几个高级官僚奏事并予以回应就不难意识到这个问题。无论是马里帝国还是平安中期的日本，君主所能拥有的基础性权力是很弱的。汉武帝所处的情况则完全不同，他需要在七八百万平方公里，生活着三四千万人口的庞大地区内采取高强度的政治、经济、军事行动长达半个世纪，并且组织对这个区域以外的外部世界进行探索。与日本天皇名义上的“治天”不同，刘彻其人是在真正行使“治天”的权力，在整个前工业时代，帝国的基础性权力前所未有地深入基层。他既没必要，也不大可能通过常规地显示专制权力的办法来增强自己权威。例如这个人根本就没法保持多少神秘感和距离感，因为他需要不停地和幕僚商议国家政策，从全国各地接收各个阶层的奏书并且予以回复，出现在各种大型典礼场合以示国家“更化改制”，不断地出巡并且接见地方的利益团体代表（比如山东沿海的方士）对他们进行安抚和拉拢。当皇帝本人需要以最快的效率处理政务，基础性权力已经大到在当年的技术水平下难以行使时，他自然没有必要把注意力放在各种祝圣仪式上。而且我们也不应该忘记所谓专制型权力的定义，这种权力的显示本身就意味着对于其他政治参与方话语权的蔑视，不得罪人是不可能的。哪怕是被视为神或者神的后裔的君主，在本质上也是一个普通人，脖子上被砍一刀也会死。因此对于任何理智的统治者而言，在完全没有必要显示专制权力的时候，平白无故招惹根本难以预测的风险显得就极为愚蠢，而刘彻本人无疑是一个极其聪明的统治者。

我们用一个有趣的事例说明汉武帝本人是怎样避免过度显示其专制性权力的，也就是发生在元鼎三年冬（元鼎三年为前114年，不过不要忘了在太初历之前，我国以冬为岁首）的函谷关东迁事件。汉帝国将函谷关这个首都长安的最重要的门户和关隘从现在的灵宝市东迁到新安市，而文献记载将这决定指向了时任主爵都尉杨仆（依照东汉学者应劭的注），他以酷吏的身份位列九卿。杨仆是宜阳人（汉代宜阳比今天的宜阳要略偏西一些，根据《中国历史地图集》），给汉武帝上书说，现在关中的土地都奖赏给了有功之臣，他们已经成为高门显贵，自己的家乡却在函谷关以东，感觉低人一等。于是请求把函谷关东迁到新安市，这样杨仆的家乡就被恰好包括在关内了。现在的人当然会感觉到这种记载多么离谱，且不说一个皇帝会为了一个官员的请求就做出如此重大的决定，而且就食邑的位置来说它并未表现出明显等级区别。例如骠骑大将军霍去病的食邑冠军县位于南阳郡，日后属于荆州刺史部；大司马大将军卫青的食邑长平县位于汝南郡，日后属于兖州刺史部。（函谷关东扩时，卫青本人和霍去病之子都在世）这两个地方日后都不在司隶校尉的监察范围内，不是三辅三河、弘农这样的畿辅重地，卫霍两人出身的河东地区也不属于关中，虽然在地理上是自然延伸。而杨仆本人后来因为平定南方的武功被封为梁侯，梁县却是真的在以洛阳为首府的河南郡，而且就在宜阳东南方向不远处（宜阳县归属弘农郡，在函谷关东扩之后属于“关中”了）。但是很显然无论从地位的尊贵，还是从个人能力及在国家决策中发挥的作用，还是从受到皇帝信任甚至是寄托了某些重要情感的角度来说，杨仆都不可能跟卫青霍去病相比，仅仅几年后杨仆就因为自己在征服朝鲜中的拙劣表现被贬为庶民。由此可见汉武帝不可能只是为了给杨仆一个面子就让函谷关东扩，杨仆自己也不可能相信自己有这么大的脸面敢这样请求皇帝。

实际上我们从后来元封五年（前 106 年）划分司隶及十三刺史部这项措施中可以看到函谷关东扩大地缘政治上的意义。函谷关东扩之后，第二年在京兆东面新设的弘农郡立刻就成为京师长安的锁钥，这个郡的地理界限被四个重要的关隘所限制，分别是西北方的旧函谷关，东北方的新函谷关（设置一个关都尉），东南方的武关（设置一个关都尉），以及西南方的峽关（也就是后来的蓝关，韩愈被贬斥曾经经过此地）。前三个关隘都在地理上属于弘农郡，峽关大概直接隶属京兆，同时在旧函谷关以西不远的华阴是京辅都尉的驻地，这也就是说弘农直面东方的防御力量虽然强，但是在西侧面对首都的一方仍然被京兆严格防范和限制。新函谷关距离洛阳仅仅 30 千米，军队可以朝发夕至，仅仅用快马传递信息那就更迅速了。其实从地缘上说把新函谷关作为关中的东大门是非常离谱的，因为离得也太远了，但是函谷关的确是洛阳非常合适的西大门。在东汉末年汉灵帝为了防御黄巾军在首都洛阳附近设置的八个关隘中，新函谷关位列第一，哪怕黄巾军起义的地区基本在洛阳的东面而非西面。经过这样的关隘建设和行政区划调整，汉帝国政府在国家内部完成了一次惊人的地缘扩张，现在作为三辅的左冯翊、右扶风、京兆尹，作为三河的河东郡、河内郡、河南郡，以及连接两个地区的弘农郡都被划入司隶。司隶向东延伸到黄河稳定河道的尽头，再往下游则河水容易泛滥成灾，瓠子决口在当时也刚刚堵塞没几年。

在中原以北，依《汉书 文三王传》和《史记 汉兴以来诸侯王年表》所载，汉武帝将代王转封到清河，原先的封地改为太原郡。经过这样的调整，太行山以西已经不再存在诸侯王国。并州刺史部（包括现在山西大部）东侧的太行山脉历来属于天堑，通过少数几个关口的道路情况极为险恶，西南方跨越黄河的主要渡口又被河东郡控制，上党高地东南方则是河内郡。这样一来太行山以西的并州，囊括了从匈奴处夺取的河套，河西走廊地区的朔方和凉州两个刺史部也在朝廷控制下。

在南方，汉武帝作为老奸巨猾的地缘政治家故技重施，在隶属于益州刺史部的巴郡（郡治在今天重庆），帝国设置江关都尉驻扎在鱼复（巴郡管辖范围的东端，以东则是荆州），也就是后来的白帝城所在位置，今天的奉节。而在东部与巴郡相连的是属于荆州刺史部的南郡（郡治江陵，现在的荆州市），该郡都尉则驻扎在江陵上游的夷陵，今天的宜昌市。在鱼复和夷陵两地之间，就是现在大家常说的长江三峡地区（属于南郡）。在更靠南的益州刺史部南部的牂牁郡，帝国在红河上游设置了进桑关，并令该郡南部都尉驻扎在进桑县。在牂牁江上游设置柱蒲关，柱蒲关的具体位置没有记载，不过根据汉武帝时期设关隘时附近会驻守一个都尉的一般规律来推测，这个关隘很可能在元光年间就已经设置的夜郎都尉驻地附近。这两个益州南部的关隘分别从珠江和红河上游对整个交趾地区（这个概念在当年包含广西，广东大部和越南中北部）实现了威慑，一旦当地有变，汉军就可以立刻顺流而下进行平叛。这样一来，汉武帝在短短数年间就完成了在《汉书》中被称为“扩关”的内部地缘政治扩张。

这样一来我们从地图上就看到了一条显出形状的线，也就是我国地理上第二阶梯和第三阶梯的交界线。汉武帝将以长安为首都的中央政府能够确保控制的边界向东推移到了这条线上，尤其包含了河内郡、河南郡这一带天下的中心地区，通过修建道路、运河、关隘和调整行政区划将关中地区的地缘控制力扩张到中国的整个第二阶梯地区。在十四个监察大区中，朔方、并州、凉州、益州和司隶五个位于第二阶梯，属于朝廷的基本盘；幽州、冀州、青州、兖州、豫州、徐州、荆州、扬州和交趾九个位于朝廷需要防范的第三阶梯。这样一来，朝廷严密掌控的关西（扩张后的）中国第二阶梯地区与有所防范的关东第三阶梯地区相比虽然从人口和经济上还不能说有优势（按照《汉书》数据，扩张后的关西地区人口占全国三成左右），但是一旦考虑到山川地理的形势，关系和关东的力量就相对平衡。再加上朝廷所拥有的优势，包括大义名分、武备和财政，凭借关西压制关东就是可以实现的事了。

我认为这种调整在某种程度上反映了国家体制变革带给汉帝国决策层的焦虑。虽然秦国以关中和巴蜀为基本盘就完成了中国的初次统一，汉朝初年一定程度上继承了战国晚期的地缘政治格局。然而秦国的地缘优势某种意义上讲是建立在诸侯割据的情况下，也即秦国本身完全不足以压倒其他诸侯国领土、人口和经济的总和，但是因为中国从行政上和认同上还没有完成整合，关东诸侯不可能一心一意合兵攻秦。等到汉武帝执政后期，中国的内部整合正在走向完成，对匈奴的战争可能加速了这个过程。虽然大一统的局面大大增强了长安朝廷所能支配的，在全国各个地方的基础性权力，可是也不可能不带来这样一个问题。当地方上的自治力量几乎完全消失，长安变成一个大一统的集权国家的首都时，它所面临的威胁就不只是个别诸侯国了。换句话说，以前的首都只需要对于国家的各个地理单元分别具有明显优势，而现在帝国的首都需要能够实现对于整个国家实现全面的压制。经年累月的战争带来的社会压力，加上推行盐铁官营，将铸币权收归中央之后关东地区必然产生不满情绪。像汉武帝这样经验极为丰富的统治者不可能没有认识，他在完成国家内部地缘战略调整的同时自己也开始一次又一次前往东方巡视。

因为出于这样比较隐蔽的，不太方便公之于众的庞大战略目的，汉武帝没有自己提出计划的第一步，而是让一个家乡正好就在新函谷关附近的，朝廷的新贵来提出，并且在八年间分步执行，这就显得高明许多了。尽管皇帝本人无疑可以行使专制权力，但是在没有必要非得这样做的情况下，在形式上尊重朝廷既定的法度只有好处没有坏处，即使从政策推行的角度来说，受到的疑虑和阻碍也会小一些。武帝执政时期发生过许多这样的事，例如他将太一立为主神祭祀，史书中依然说这是采纳了方士的进谏。不过其实大家一想也能明白，哪怕古典国家有转向单一主神崇拜的倾向（增强统一），随便一个方士吹吹耳旁风，皇帝就同意是不是也太离谱了。即使在宗教影响相对弱的地方，更换祭祀的主神也绝对不是随便的事。皇帝暗中授意别人提出，并且以一副虚心纳谏的样子命令执行，就避免了过度显示专制权力可能带来的不满。所以说很多大权在握的统治者往往表现出一副宽容和重视公议的形象，而越是看起来专断独行的统治者，他的统治很可能远非人们想的一样稳固。

不止如此，与一般的想象不同，汉武帝对于意识形态的管控相当松弛，在某种意义上近似于不管。例如公开的政治反对派淮南王刘安谋反未遂被杀却允许《淮南子》一书一直留存下来（有至少一本就存放在未央宫石渠阁），国家官方支持今文经学但是一样允许古文经学发展并任用学古文经学的官员。国家的官方意识形态的基石是儒家六经，不过阴阳家的学说一样被重视，像浑天说这样否认“天圆地方”的理论一样被允许传播，在制定新历法的时候，只以实际效果为准。到后来“今古文之争”和“浑盖之争”都越来越激化了。哪怕人们只看汉武帝时期作为国家主导意识形态的公羊儒学，都很难不承认这种意识形态对于一般的君主来说的确不易驾驭，下一段我们就会看到汉武帝去世之后思想风向的迅速转变。

人们一般会笼统地说：封建化进程削弱了古典君主的权力。但是如果准确地讲，比起削弱君主的专制性权力，封建化更多是在削弱君主的基础性权力，因为封建生产关系使得自然经济抬头。在古典国家度过其鼎盛时期，也就是阶级过渡基本完成，封建生产成为主流之后，古典帝国的基础性权力就开始衰退了。统治者为了补偿基础性权力的衰退，往往会设法增加专制性权力，而最主要的手段在于强化仪式，神化统治者以及鼓吹神秘主义。于是我们在世界各个古典帝国走向衰退的时候都看到了高度一致的现象，哪怕相隔万里，皇帝们仿佛心有灵犀一样采取了相同的行动。例如说，在罗马帝国晚期至拜占庭帝国早期和西汉后期至东汉前期，罗马和中国的皇帝非常喜欢进行“经义裁决”，也就是通过召开大会来由皇帝裁决什么是信经什么是伪经，谁是正统谁是异端（分别对于基督教和儒学）。在公元九世纪，阿拔斯王朝的哈里发开始实行宗教裁判政策，而印度本土最后一个统一北印度的君主戒日王，同样非常喜欢组织宗教辩论大会，玄奘法师本人就在曲女城参与过。这些处于古典社会瓦解时期的君主们想尽办法抬高自己的权威，汉宣帝通过石渠阁会议抬高了《春秋谷梁传》的地位，而《谷梁传》相对于《公羊传》更加保守并倾向于维护现有的礼制。

神化工作自然也不能停，从公元二世纪后期开始，罗马统治者在尊号上就越来越向波斯的同行看齐，最终完成了第一公民到人间的神（戴克里先，Diocletian）这一转变。高棉帝国最后一位伟大的神王阇耶跋摩七世放弃了印度教而支持大乘佛教（关于佛教的问题本章第二十七节就会说道，这里读者可以先默认大乘佛教更加有利于君主专制），在吴哥修建了更加宏大的建筑，并且将自己的形象用雕刻永远记录下来（就是所谓“高棉的微笑”），他去世之后高棉帝国就一路走向衰落了。阿拔斯王朝发生的事情一模一样，当哈里发国家在政治上越是不可避免地走向解体时，哈里发就越强调自己在宗教上的权威，让自己的尊号与安拉的名字相连，例如“真主在地面上的影子”。不过变化最激烈并且最显著的还得数中国，这大概也是因为中国的封建化进程在那个阶段最为猛烈。在整个东汉，对汉朝统治者被神化愈发明显（尤其是已经去世两个世纪的西汉开国皇帝刘邦），阴阳学说被用来巩固王朝统治，最广为人知的成果即汉朝被认为是属于“火德”。光武帝刘秀开始利用谶纬神学这样的神秘主义理论为自己的合法性背书，他死之后石兽、石人列于陵前，形成的陵墓形制中的一个新部分，在中国被称为“神道”。汉明帝刘庄非常善于利用梦境增强自己的神秘色彩，他主动地引入了佛教，并且用鞭杖这样严厉的肉体惩罚来羞辱朝臣。汉章帝刘炟在位时召开的白虎观会议以及事后班固奉命总结成的《白虎通》将神秘主义和造神运动推向一个高潮，谶纬之术被强行和儒学“共融”“三纲六纪”被官方予以肯定，纲常伦理被系统化，日后成为复辟官僚国家的意识形态基础。神秘主义当然也不是只发生在中国，在北印度已经普遍开始封建化的时期，波罗王朝（Pala Empire）统治下的佛教发生了重大变化，密宗修行在那烂陀寺

（Nalanda mahavihara），飞行寺（Odantapuri）和超戒寺（Vikramashila）变得广为流行，并且得到统治者的公开支持。今天的东正教中所含有的神秘主义因素也明显要多于天主教，而且前者非常推崇圣像，这也是因为今天的东正教是在拜占庭这个晚期古典帝国发展起来的。



然而说一千道一万，无论古典帝国后期的统治者想出什么样的办法增强自己的专制性权力，都不可能弥补基础性权力的丧失。实际上，即使最终实现官僚复辟的中华帝国也不可能避免这一点，因为国家基础性权力的衰退是封建化初期最核心的特征之一，这是由封建生产关系所决定的。就像前面所提到的，虽然复辟官僚体制善于掠夺民间财富，但是它所具有的治理能力非常一般。复辟官僚制度就是一种在一般情况下专制性权力和基础性权力都较为微弱的封建时期，通过一种具有“自我意识”，由士大夫阶层支撑的，强掠夺性和强压迫性的官僚制度极大地增强了专制性权力，甚至超过了古典时期的汉朝。但是这种强到令人咋舌的专制性权力具有很大的迷惑性，经常误导国内外的观察者，让他们以为官僚复辟时期的中华帝国真的有什么不受社会经济条件支配的“超自然的”强大基础性权力。

只要脑子不犯这样的糊涂，人们就很容易明白为什么明末皇帝明明没有丧失专制性权力中国却迅速落到了满洲人手里，这不仅是因为北方社会生产的普遍崩溃，也是因为明帝国政府早就没有一点半点的基础性权力了，否则它至少能在中国南方建立一段时间的稳定统治。对于正常封建化的国家来说，基础性权力的重新增强是中世纪盛期以来社会关系重组的结果，并且随着资本主义的兴起显著提升了。这里其实就存在一个封建社会的重要特征，也就是说从早期国家发展到封建国家的过程中，虽然在古典帝国的形成期政府基础权力会增长，但到了古典社会后期政府的基础性权力必然会出现衰退，这和专制权力的变化是一致的。然而从封建国家走向资本主义国家时，政府的基础性权力会一直增长。在第二个过渡期基础权力的变化与专制性权力趋势就不一致了，专制性权力的变化趋势仍然是在封建国家到近世国家这个过程中增长，然后在近世国家演变成为资本主义民主国家时衰退。中国在复辟官僚体制下完全没办法出现这个过程，因此等到最后一个君主专制的王朝清朝统治的时候，虽然看起来中国皇帝比当时全世界任何一个统治者的专制权力都大，但是就政府所拥有的基础性权力而言，清朝早就被西欧国家甩开了。

在这里我们同样指出一个全世界都容易感到迷惑的概念，那就是“中国的中央集权”。今天人们说到“中央集权”的时候，几乎根本没有人意这个“权”到底是哪个“权”。我在这里明确指出，中国的中央集权指的是集中专制性权力，而不是集中基础性权力。简单来说，就是把一切不受制度和公约所限制的，随意破坏既定社会秩序的能力集中到中央，严格限制任何地方拥有这种能力。但是就通过各种社会基础设施渗透和协调社会各个领域的的能力，复辟官僚国家并没有过于中央集权，更没有能力去将其集中到中央政府行使。因此我们看到在司法、教育、水利等等问题上，朝廷的存在感并不高，真正理事的是地方的乡贤。只有理解了这一点，我们才能够理解为什么专制主义中央集权和“皇权不下乡”能够被同时观察到。从本质来说，朝廷渴望拥有的是侵略性的压制能力，而绝不是服务性的管理能力。我们当然不能否认在复辟官僚社会下地方乡贤的确也可以通过提供公共服务的方式获得社会地位和一定权力，但这些都是丝毫不受任何保障的。在将近一千年的时间里，专制性权力和基础性权力的分离使得中国社会越来越严重的处于权责不对等的状态，并且塑造了病态的社会意识，使得整个国家的社会效率几近于零，最终也会摧毁每一个政权的政治效率。讲明白这一点，任何人都可以很轻易的理解为什么中国这样一个“中央集权”的大帝国会看起来如此无能 and 笨拙。因此同样是“中央集权”，这个“权”字所指不同就可以反映两种截然不同的社会存在。例如公元 1066 年诺曼征服之后的中世纪英格兰，我们也可以说英格兰是一个“中央集权国家”，然而与中国相比，英王更多集中的就是基础性权力而非专制性权力了。只要人们联想到《末日审判书》或是巡回法官，自然就能意识到英格兰王国在基础性权力上已经于中世纪盛期取得了领先世界的优势，这不是中国的复辟官僚国家能够相比的。

在我国，政府所拥有的基础性权力迅速增长到现代水平是“先锋队制度”被引入之后的事，是苏联布尔什维克体制在中国建立的结果。实际上我在这里有一个猜想，即由苏联所首创的所谓无产阶级专政制度是否是没有正常经历封建社会后期社会重组过程的国家得以在短期内迅速提升政府的基础性权力的“法宝”。不过这个“法宝”不可能真的带来封建化过程所产生的一系列必要的社会组织（比如说，议会，工会）和社会意识（比如说人权），而且副作用非常要命，那就是专制性权力变得更强大和不受限制了，整个国家对于近现代文明的抵制变得更加剧烈。而且从另一方面来说，虽然基础性权力扩大但是不代表权力在使用上的倾向发生了变化，掠夺性和压迫性的官僚体制并没有演化成为治理性的官僚体制。不过由于要想解答这个问题需要考察的政权都十分封闭，各种秘密档案人们无从得知，我在国内因为政治原因能见到的就更少。因此，这个问题的回答可能最终还是要靠国外学者。